How to mix the colour and its shades

One name, several forms. Indigo is the name of a dye and also of a colour shade. The traditional indigo dye gives fabrics a blue colour. In today's colour charts “indigo” may denote a deep blue and also a more striking blue-violet, and individual painting brands offer different mixes under this name. That is why there is no single tube that is the one correct indigo. For our card imagine **a deep blue with a slight violet tint**. Blue still predominates in it.

Real dyeing with indigo has its own little show. In traditional dyeing the dye is first chemically treated so that it can pass into the dye bath. The fabric may look yellow-green when pulled out and only **turn blue in the air**. The change is caused by contact with oxygen. When painting with ordinary paints do not expect such a change. The deep shade here is made by mixing ready-made colours.

What to prepare



Blue
The base of the mix. Ultramarine is a striking blue with a slightly violet tint.



White
For lighter and denim variants.



Black
Or for darkening. Use it sparingly so that the mix does not lose its colour.



Magenta
A pinkish red that carefully pushes blue towards violet.



Brown
In a tiny amount for more muted ink tones.

How can you recognise it without technical names?

Indigo side by side quickly shows whether it is **bluer** or **more violet**. A bluer one recalls denim and ink, a more violet one the evening sky just before dark. The names on tubes differ between makers, so put small samples side by side and **add white** to part of them. You will then see the hidden tint better.

On the tube look for the marking **PB** (Pigment Blue) and **PV** (Pigment Violet) and a number. It tells you which pigments the mix is made of, even when the names differ.

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What the additions do



Magenta

Pushes towards violet, plum. Add by the tip, it easily takes over.





White

Lightens and leads to denim and dusk. Add little by little.





Brown

Mutes towards ink. Too much brown quickly makes it a dirty grey.





Black

Darkens, but flattens. Add only on the tip of the brush.





Orange

The opposite of blue. In a tiny amount it calms and softens indigo.





Blue

Returns it to bluer, denim and ink.



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Ten indigos to try

A part can be a drop, or a pile of paint of the same size. **Take the proportions as a starting point for trying things out**, not as a recipe for a cake. The strength of pigments differs and dark colours can take command surprisingly fast. Start with blue. Magenta is meant to turn the mix slightly, it does not have to take the lead in it.

Classic indigo



6 parts blue + 1 part red or magenta. Deep, calm, a little mysterious.

Bluer indigo



4 parts darker blue + a tiny addition of magenta. The proportion is approximate, add the magenta really by the tip.

Blue-violet indigo



3 parts blue + about 1 part magenta, fine-tune according to the result. Closer to violet, but still with a blue base.

Midnight



6 parts ultramarine + 1 part brown + a trace of magenta, possibly a tiny bit of black. A deep night in which stars can be found.

Denim



4 parts blue + 1 part white + a drop of brown. Comfortable, everyday, washed.

Dusk



1 part indigo + 3 parts white. Soft, dreamy, gently sad.

Smoky blue-violet



1 part indigo + 3 parts white + a tiny trace of brown. Like mist over water.

Plum



3 parts indigo + 1 part red or magenta. Richer, warmer, closer to violet.

Grey indigo



3 parts indigo + 2 parts white + a trace of orange. Calm, elegant. Orange is the opposite of blue and mutes it.

Slate



3 parts indigo + 1 part grey + a pinch of green. Cool, sober, grounded.

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